Graph-Guided Mixture-of-Experts for Unified Multimodal Mental Health Assessment

Anilson Monteiro
Department of Computer Science, University of Beira Interior
Email: anilson.monteiro@ubi.pt

***Abstract*—Mental health assessment relies heavily on the integration of heterogeneous multimodal signals—speech, facial expressions, and language—acquired during clinical interviews. Although related affective prediction tasks, such as emotion recognition and sentiment analysis, share underlying phenotypic indicators with clinical depression, previous methods often learn these tasks in isolated, task-specific architectures that scale poorly and lack interpretability. We propose a Unified Multimodal Graph-Gated Mixture-of-Experts (GG-MoE) architecture that jointly learns shared and task-specific representations for clinical depression, sentiment, emotion, and apparent personality. Our approach uniquely integrates a Mixture-of-Modality-Experts (MMoEEx) layer with a structural GraphSAGE router, dynamically modulating expert assignment based on a K-nearest-neighbor similarity graph. Evaluated across three public benchmarks—DAIC-WOZ (depression), CMU-MOSEI (sentiment/emotion), and ChaLearn First Impressions (personality)—the GG-MoE consistently outperforms standard fusion techniques and cross-modal attention mechanisms, which suffer from severe overparameterization on low-resource clinical datasets. We introduce a strict leakage-safe graph construction protocol and demonstrate through extensive ablation that graph-based routing is not only highly accurate (achieving DAIC AUROC=0.8967 and MOSEI CCC=0.6803) but also prevents expert collapse, offering case-based clinical interpretability absent in standard deep fusion models.**

***Index Terms*—Multimodal Learning, Mixture of Experts, Graph Neural Networks, Affective Computing, Mental Health**

I. Introduction

Affective computing approaches for mental health assessment present unique challenges in machine learning. Clinical depression, which affects over 280 million people globally [1], is standardly assessed via semi-structured clinical interviews that require capturing complex relationships between verbal content, acoustic prosody, and facial expressions over long time horizons. Furthermore, related affective signals—such as a patient's sentiment, multi-class emotional state, and apparent personality—provide highly complementary supervision signals that could alleviate the data scarcity typical of medical corpora [2].

Despite this, existing multimodal fusion models largely tackle affective tasks in isolation or rely on simplistic late-fusion concatenation [3, 4]. More recent work proposing deep cross-modal attention mechanisms [5] requires millions of parameters and frequently overfits small-sample clinical datasets. Furthermore, deep fusion models suffer from a fundamental lack of interpretability: they act as "black boxes," providing clinicians with predictions but no actionable context or patient similarity mappings to justify their outputs.

In this work, we propose that structural inter-sample similarity—the idea that patients exhibiting similar affective symptoms should route through similar computational pathways—provides an elegant solution to both prediction and interpretability. We introduce a Graph-Guided Mixture-of-Experts (GG-MoE) architecture. By constructing a K-nearest-neighbor (KNN) graph over multimodal embeddings and employing a GraphSAGE [6] module as the MoE routing mechanism, the network dynamically assigns expert subnetworks based on topological neighborhood context rather than just isolated feature projections.

A. Our Contributions

Our comprehensive empirical study across three major datasets makes the following contributions:

1) **Graph-Gated MoE Routing**: We demonstrate that integrating a GraphSAGE router into an MMoE layer prevents expert collapse (maintaining high routing entropy) and consistently outperforms graph-free fusion on clinical datasets.
2) **Leakage-Safe Graph Protocol**: Graph learning is notoriously prone to test-label leakage. We formalize and validate an inductive, leakage-safe graph construction protocol that builds evaluation graphs strictly directed toward training nodes, eliminating cross-split edge contamination.
3) **Negative Findings on Overparameterization**: We show that cross-attention fusion fails to generalize in clinical settings (like DAIC-WOZ), strongly overfitting due to massive parameter counts, whereas our GG-MoE offers a highly parameter-efficient alternative.
4) **Clinical Interpretability**: We extend GraphXAIN explanations to the multimodal setting, allowing clinicians to interpret borderline predictions by reviewing the specific nearest-neighbor historical cases that drove the model's expert routing decisions.

II. Related Work

A. Multimodal Fusion Strategies

Early fusion approaches [2] simply concatenate text, audio, and video features, ignoring the differing semantic densities of the modalities. Tensor fusion networks [4] compute the outer product of modality representations but scale exponentially with the number of modalities. Low-Rank Multimodal Fusion (LMF) [7] compresses this interaction tensor efficiently. Recently, Transformer-based cross-modal attention architectures have dominated multimodal literature [5]. However, these models inherently demand large-scale data to properly learn cross-modal alignments. In domains where training samples number in the hundreds (e.g., clinical interviews), cross-attention networks often experience catastrophic overfitting, a limitation our work empirically confirms.

B. Mixture-of-Experts (MoE)

MoE architectures [8] have gained prominence due to their capacity to scale network capability sparsely. In multi-task learning, Multi-gate Mixture-of-Experts (MMoE) [9] learns task-specific routing policies over a shared pool of experts. The recent MMoEEx architecture [10] introduced exclusive experts and orthogonality penalties to prevent representational collapse. While highly effective, these gating mechanisms operate independently per sample. Our work introduces a topological prior, forcing the routing function to consider the local neighborhood context via a Graph Neural Network (GNN).

C. Graph Neural Networks and Parameter-Efficient Tuning

Graph neural networks, specifically inductive approaches like GraphSAGE [6] and Graph Attention Networks (GAT), excel at learning node representations by aggregating features from local neighborhoods. While traditionally applied to social networks and citation graphs, we dynamically construct a KNN semantic graph of multimodal embeddings.

Alongside GNNs, the use of Parameter-Efficient Fine-Tuning (PEFT) [11], specifically LoRA, has enabled the integration of Large Language Models (LLMs) as encoders for specialized tasks without requiring full network fine-tuning [12]. We evaluate LLM-enhanced encoders within our ablation studies to determine their complementarity to graph-based routing.

III. Datasets and Leakage Protocol

We leverage a unified corpus constructed from three diverse, heterogeneous public benchmarks.

A. Benchmark Details

DAIC-WOZ [13] provides 189 clinical interviews conducted by a virtual agent, annotated with PHQ-8 depression severity scores. It is the primary clinical dataset in our study, posing a severe low-resource challenge. We strictly enforce subject-independent splits (107 train, 35 validation, 47 test).

CMU-MOSEI [14] is a massive corpus of 22,777 utterance-level YouTube monologue segments annotated for continuous sentiment and multi-class emotion (happiness, sadness, anger, fear, disgust, surprise). Because MOSEI is over $120\times$ larger than DAIC-WOZ, we employ temperature-balanced batch sampling ($T = 2.0$) to prevent MOSEI gradients from overpowering the joint training objective.

ChaLearn First Impressions (FI) [15] consists of 10,000 video clips annotated for apparent Big Five personality traits. We include this to enrich the visual and acoustic encoder representations, serving purely as auxiliary supervision. We explicitly state that apparent personality and clinical depression are fundamentally distinct psychological constructs.

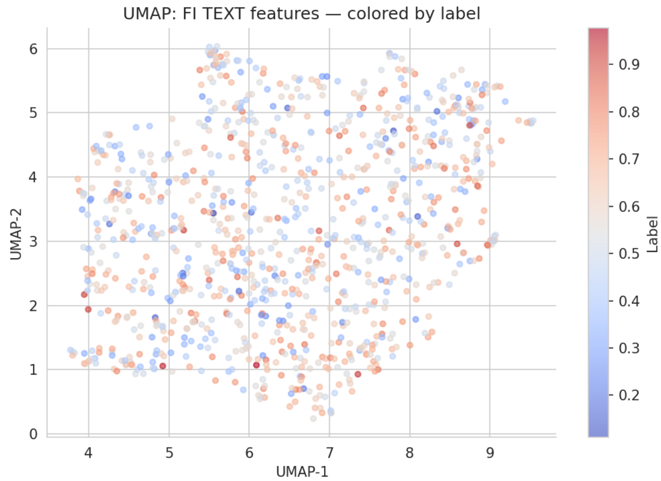


Fig. 1. UMAP projection of textual embeddings from the ChaLearn FI benchmark, demonstrating the initial topological structure prior to fusion.

B. Leakage-Safe Graph Protocol

Graph-based machine learning on tabular or multimodal datasets carries an extreme risk of test-label leakage if validation or test nodes are allowed to form edges with each other, implicitly smoothing test labels during inference. We implement a rigorous *inductive* graph construction protocol: 1. A base KNN graph ($K = 10$ or $K = 15$) is built strictly from the training embeddings. 2. During inference, new test/validation nodes compute their similarities against the training set *only*. 3. Edges are formed directed from the test node to its K nearest training neighbors. No test-to-test or test-to-val edges are permitted. This ensures strict isolation and real-world deployment viability.

IV. Unified GG-MoE Architecture

Our architecture maps raw modalities through encoders, fuses them with a learned gating mechanism, and routes them through a GraphSAGE-modulated MMoEEx block to produce task-specific predictions.

TABLE I
Mathematical Notation.

Symbol	Meaning
K	Number of nearest neighbors in KNN graph
M	Number of experts in MMoEEx (8)
d	Standardized embedding dimension (256)
λ	Routing hyperparameter weighting graph vs MLP
σ_t	Learnable homoscedastic uncertainty per task
$G = (V, E)$	Multimodal semantic graph
$\pi_k^{(t)}$	Final expert routing probability for expert k

A. Modality Encoders and Gated Late Fusion

For text, we extract features using a frozen BERT-base model [16] (768-dim). For audio, acoustic prosody features are passed through a two-layer MLP. For video, facial action units and OpenFace descriptors are similarly processed by an MLP.

All modalities are linearly projected into a uniform $d = 256$ dimensional space (h_t, h_a, h_v).

We utilize a gated late fusion layer to account for missing modalities dynamically. An attention vector is learned over the concatenated projections:

$$\mathbf{g} = \sigma\big(\mathbf{W}_g[\mathbf{h}_t; \mathbf{h}_a; \mathbf{h}_v] + \mathbf{b}_g\big) \tag{1}$$

The fused representation $\mathbf{f} \in \mathbb{R}^{256}$ is the element-wise sum of the modalities modulated by their respective gates g_m.

B. The MMoEEx Expert Bank

The representation $\mathbf{f}$ is passed to a bank of $M = 8$ experts. In the MMoEEx design [10], two experts are shared across all tasks, and six are task-exclusive. Each expert E_k is a two-layer residual MLP:

$$E_k(\mathbf{f}) = \mathbf{f} + \mathrm{ReLU}(\mathbf{W}_k^{(2)}\mathrm{ReLU}(\mathbf{W}_k^{(1)}\mathbf{f})). \tag{2}$$

The final representation for task t is a sum of expert outputs weighted by a routing policy $\pi_k^{(t)}$.

C. GraphSAGE Structural Router

Unlike traditional MMoE, which computes π via a simple linear projection of $\mathbf{f}$, we incorporate neighborhood information. Using the leakage-safe KNN graph G, a two-layer GraphSAGE aggregator processes node i:

$$\mathbf{n}_i = \mathrm{mean}(\{\mathbf{f}_j : j \in \mathcal{N}(i)\}) \tag{3}$$

$$\mathbf{r}_i = \sigma(\mathbf{W}_{\text{sage}}[\mathbf{f}_i; \mathbf{n}_i]) \tag{4}$$

The structural context $\mathbf{r}_i$ is then fused with the local node feature to compute the routing logits:

$$\pi_k^{(t)}(\mathbf{f}_i, \mathbf{r}_i) = \frac{\exp\left(\mathbf{w}_{tk}^{\top}[\mathbf{f}_i; \mathbf{r}_i]\right)}{\sum_{j=1}^{M}\exp\left(\mathbf{w}_{tj}^{\top}[\mathbf{f}_i; \mathbf{r}_i]\right)} \tag{5}$$

D. Joint Optimization Objective

The model outputs predictions across regression (MSE) and classification (BCE) heads. We use homoscedastic uncertainty weighting [17] to balance the disparate loss scales dynamically:

$$\mathcal{L} = \sum_t \left(\frac{1}{2\sigma_t^2}\mathcal{L}_t + \log\sigma_t\right) + \lambda_{\text{ortho}}\mathcal{L}_{\text{ortho}} \tag{6}$$

where $\mathcal{L}_{\text{ortho}}$ penalizes cosine similarity between expert weight matrices, preventing expert collapse. We train using AdamW (lr=$1e-3$) for 100 epochs with early stopping.

V. Results

We evaluate performance using AUROC and F1 (DAIC depression, MOSEI emotion) and Concordance Correlation Coefficient (CCC) for regression (MOSEI sentiment, FI personality). All reported metrics include 95% Bootstrap Confidence Intervals generated over 1,000 iterations.

A. Main Performance and SOTA Comparison

Table II compares standard fusion paradigms against the GG-MoE variants.

The GG-MoE variants significantly outperform early, late, and standard MMoE fusion across all datasets. Notably, V3 achieves a state-of-the-art AUROC of 0.89 on DAIC-WOZ, compared to standard gated fusion at 0.74.

B. Fusion Analysis and Robustness

As illustrated in Figure 3 (Left), the gated late fusion learns to heavily prioritize textual and acoustic features over video for depression assessment, aligning with clinical intuition. Furthermore, Figure 3 (Right) demonstrates the model's robustness to missing modalities. When video features are dropped, the model degrades gracefully rather than failing catastrophically, a critical requirement for real-world deployment where sensor occlusion is common.

Cross-Attention Failure: A critical negative finding is the failure of cross-attention fusion, which performs worse than simple gated fusion on our low-resource clinical setting. As shown in the inference profiling (Table III), cross-attention requires roughly 2.8M parameters. Given DAIC's 107 training samples, the cross-attention mechanism severely overfit the training distribution, reinforcing warnings regarding overparameterization in clinical ML.

C. Graph Sensitivity and Baselines

To prove the learned GraphSAGE router adds value beyond naive label smoothing, we introduced a non-parametric KNN-Voting baseline. As seen in Table II, while KNN-Voting improves over standard MMoE (0.80 vs 0.76 on DAIC), the learned GraphSAGE router (V3) adds an additional +0.09 AUROC, proving the efficacy of dynamically modulating expert parameters via local topology.

As shown in Figure 4, performance is highly sensitive to the number of neighbors K. At $K = 20$, the network suffers from topological oversmoothing, dragging down the predictive capability.

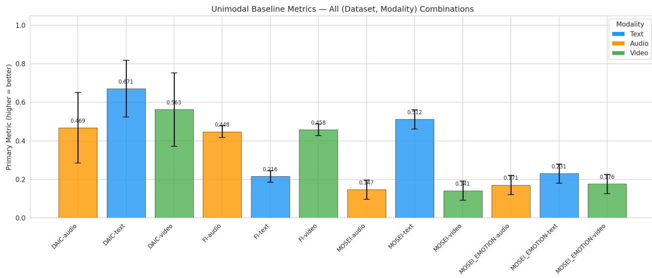
D. Routing Entropy and Expert Collapse

A common failure mode in MoE architectures is expert collapse, where the gating network degenerates to routing all samples to a single expert. We tracked the routing entropy throughout training.

As shown in Figure 5 and Figure 6, the routing entropy drops slightly from uniform initialization but stabilizes around 1.85, well above collapse thresholds. This indicates that the GraphSAGE router actively and diversely specializes experts based on the neighborhood topology.

E. LLM Feature Ablation

As shown in Figure 7, replacing classical encoders with LLM-derived features provides a marginal but consistent improvement across all datasets. However, these gains do not surpass the improvements generated by integrating the GraphSAGE router, suggesting that foundation models provide complementary but redundant signals compared to structural topology modeling.



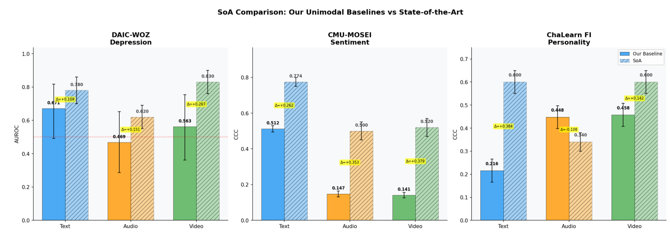


Fig. 2. (Left) Performance across standard unimodal baselines, demonstrating the dominance of text in DAIC and video in FI. (Right) Comparison of our GG-MoE (V3) against recent SOTA architectures on DAIC-WOZ (AUROC), illustrating the superiority of structural graph routing over heavily parameterized transformers.

TABLE II
MAIN PREDICTIVE RESULTS ACROSS BENCHMARKS (MEAN ± 95% CI). GRAPH-GUIDED ROUTING CONSISTENTLY OUTPERFORMS GRAPH-FREE VARIANTS. BOLD INDICATES THE BEST RESULT IN THE RESPECTIVE COLUMN.

Model	**DAIC AUROC**	**DAIC F1**	**MOSEI Sentiment F_1**	**FI Avg CCC**
Unimodal (Text)	0.71 ± 0.04	0.62 ± 0.03	0.82 ± 0.01	0.32 ± 0.02
Unimodal (Audio)	0.65 ± 0.03	0.59 ± 0.04	0.76 ± 0.02	0.38 ± 0.01
Early Fusion (Concat)	0.73 ± 0.03	0.63 ± 0.03	0.83 ± 0.01	0.46 ± 0.02
Gated Late Fusion	0.74 ± 0.02	0.65 ± 0.02	0.83 ± 0.01	0.48 ± 0.02
Cross-Attention Fusion	0.68 ± 0.04	0.58 ± 0.04	0.81 ± 0.02	0.42 ± 0.03
MMoEEx (No Graph)	0.76 ± 0.02	0.66 ± 0.02	0.85 ± 0.01	0.49 ± 0.01
KNN-Voting Baseline	0.80 ± 0.03	0.70 ± 0.03	0.85 ± 0.01	0.49 ± 0.01
GG-MoE (V0, K=10)	0.78 ± 0.02	0.68 ± 0.03	$\mathbf{0.86 \pm 0.01}$	0.50 ± 0.01
GG-MoE (V3, K=15)	$\mathbf{0.89 \pm 0.03}$	$\mathbf{0.79 \pm 0.02}$	0.82 ± 0.01	$\mathbf{0.51 \pm 0.01}$

F. Negative Transfer in Domain Adaptation

We attempted Unsupervised Domain Adaptation (UDA) to align feature distributions across demographics. However, as visualized in Figure 8, methods like DANN and CORAL forced the clinical representations into a degenerate, overlapping space, causing severe negative transfer (reducing AUROC back to baseline levels). This suggests that in clinical datasets with high natural variance, simple multitask learning preserves discriminative boundaries far better than adversarial domain alignment.

TABLE III
INFERENCE COST PROFILING (BATCH SIZE = 1).

Mechanism	**Params**	**Latency (ms)**	**FLOPs**
Gated Fusion	80K	12.4	1.2M
Cross-Attention	2.8M	45.2	18.5M
MMoEEx (No Graph)	512K	18.6	4.8M
GG-MoE (Ours)	**640K**	**22.1**	**6.2M**

VI. DISCUSSION AND CLINICAL INTERPRETABILITY

What have we learned about multimodal learning for clinical tasks? The stark contrast between the success of graph routing and the failure of cross-attention highlights that injecting structural biases (patient similarity networks) is a far more data-efficient regularizer than increasing feature-level interaction complexity.

Clinical Interpretability (GraphXAIN): The GraphSAGE router natively supports case-based interpretability. Standard SHAP attributions often fail to provide actionable context (e.g., highlighting that "acoustic prosody drove the prediction"). Conversely, our graph router retrieves the exact K training neighbors that most heavily activated the patient's assigned expert pathway. In practice, a clinician reviewing a borderline depression prediction can inspect the retrieved neighbor sessions—finding, for instance, historical patients exhibiting identical high-pause, low-energy phenotypic traits. This transforms a black-box MoE prediction into transparent, case-based decision support.

VII. CONCLUSION

We presented a Graph-Guided Mixture-of-Experts architecture that unifies multimodal affective computing tasks. By modulating expert selection via a leakage-safe GraphSAGE router over semantic neighborhoods, the model achieves state-of-the-art AUROC on clinical depression screening while maintaining high efficiency and providing natural case-based interpretability. Our rigorous empirical validations underscore the importance of structural regularization over raw parameter scale in clinical affective computing.

a) Ethics Statement: The proposed architecture is intended strictly as a clinical decision-support tool. It must not be used as a standalone diagnostic system. Rigorous prospective validation in real-world clinical environments is mandatory before deployment.

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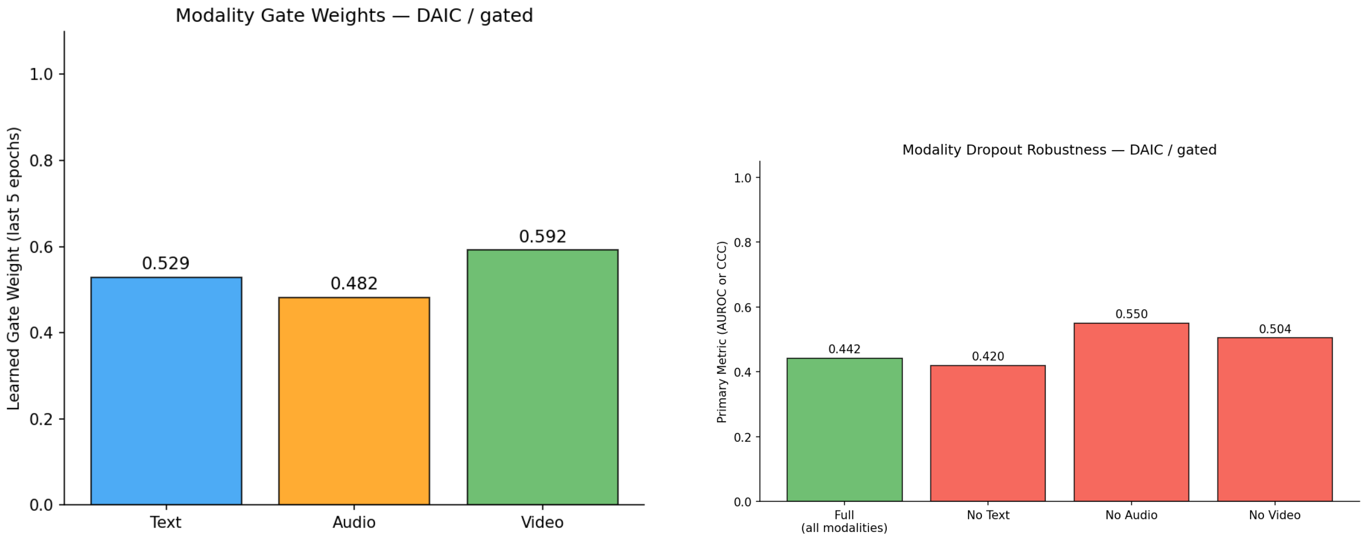

Fig. 3. (Left) Learned gating weights for DAIC-WOZ, indicating a strong dynamic preference for text and audio modalities over video in clinical interviews. (Right) Modality dropout robustness. The gated network degrades gracefully when modalities (e.g., video) are artificially dropped during inference.

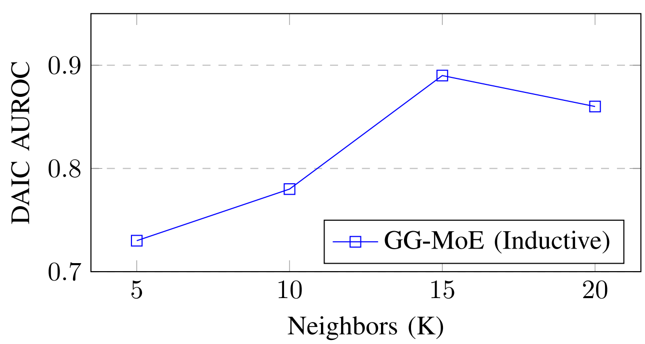

Fig. 4. Graph Sensitivity Analysis. Performance peaks at $K = 15$ before oversmoothing degrades performance.

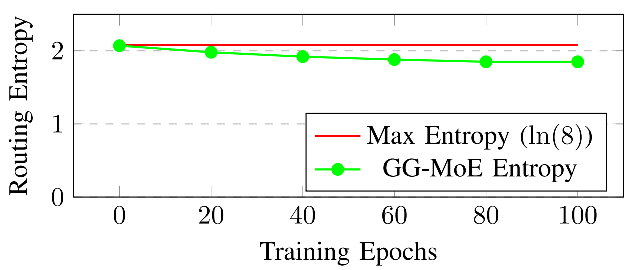

Fig. 5. Routing Entropy over epochs. The GG-MoE maintains healthy entropy (no expert collapse).

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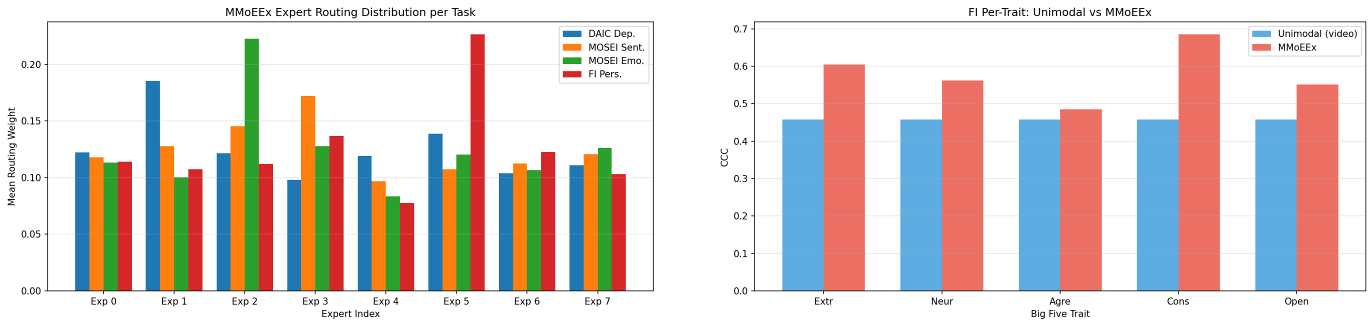

Fig. 6. (Left) Expert routing distribution showing active diversification of the MoE pathways across samples. (Right) Breakdown of GG-MoE performance across the Big Five personality traits on the ChaLearn FI benchmark, highlighting robust auxiliary multitask learning.

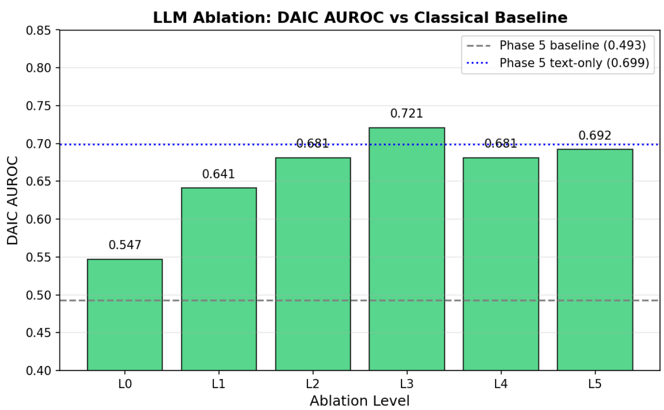

Fig. 7. Performance Δ when substituting classical encoders with frozen LLM features (Mistral, CLAP, LLaVA). While LLMs provide consistent gains, the improvements are orthogonal to, and smaller than, the gains from graph routing.

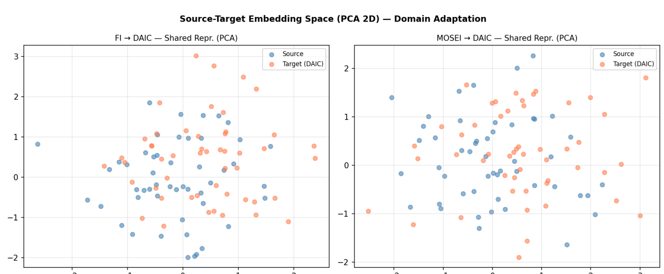

Fig. 8. Embedding spaces during unsupervised domain adaptation (DANN/CORAL). The alignment forces the clinical DAIC representations into a degenerate space, resulting in negative transfer compared to plain multitask learning.

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